

the archetypal form, as empirically determined by the consensus of the family representatives.¹ The variant can be evaluated, whenever it was introduced.

However, thought needs to be given to the exact definition of a ‘variant’. I am of the opinion that ultimately the term ‘variant’ should be reserved for readings that make a difference in the meaning, and even so, only if they were made deliberately. Of course, since an unintentional change can also alter meaning, we must proceed slowly, which is why I used the term ‘ultimately’. In the meantime, in the chart below I have omitted alternate spellings of the same word, but they are duly recorded in my full **f**³⁵ apparatus for Mark.

Mark

I invite attention to the following evidence from the Gospel of Mark. I will use E.C. Colwell’s analysis of thirteen ‘Alexandrian’ MSS in the first chapter, and my own collation of fifty-three Family 35 MSS throughout the entire book.² Here is Colwell’s own statement.

After a careful study of all alleged Beta Text-type witnesses in the first chapter of Mark, six Greek manuscripts emerged as primary witnesses: **Σ**, B, L, 33, 892, 2427. Therefore, the weaker Beta manuscripts C, D, 157, 517, 579, 1241 and 1342 were set aside. Then on the basis of the six primary witnesses an ‘average’ or mean text was reconstructed including all the readings

¹ I have determined the archetypal form of **f**³⁵ for Mark on the basis of complete collations of the 53 family representatives plotted on the chart below. The results are recorded in my full **f**³⁵ apparatus for Mark. There are seven splits that hover around 20%, four of them being alternate spellings of the same word. There are two splits that hover around 25%. None of the nine is a serious candidate for the archetypal form. There is but one serious split, hovering around 40%, it is in 13:31. Is the verb that goes with “the heaven and the earth” singular, or plural? In English the translation for either is “will pass away”, so they are two ways of saying the same thing. Although the plural has a considerable geographic distribution, the singular has far more. There are good representatives on both sides, but the five best copies have the singular. Of the five XI MSS, four have the singular. Adding it all up, the singular gets the nod.

² To someone who has never collated a Greek manuscript, I may say that it is slave labor, plain drudgery. To collate one copy of a book the size of Mark takes several days. So why do I do it? The underlying consideration is the belief that the NT books are divinely inspired, a written revelation from the Sovereign Creator. Such a revelation has objective authority, and it becomes important to have the precise original wording. If Mark were just a bit of ordinary ancient literature, the precise original wording would be of little interest. So what? What difference would it make?